“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 20

The Śikṣāṣṭaka Prayers

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 Only the fortunate can relish the words that Gauracandra spoke in His divine madness, words mingled with the joy, jealousy, anxiety, humility and anguish that love awakens.

2 Glory, glory to Gauracandra! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 Thus Mahāprabhu lived in Nīlācala, overwhelmed night and day by separation from Kṛṣṇa.

4 Night and day, in the company of these two, Svarūpa and Rāmānanda, He relished songs and verses full of *rasa*.

5 Many emotions arose in the Lord: joy, grief and anger, humility, anxiety and anguish, eager longing and contentment.

6 In each of these moods He would recite His own verses and relish their meaning with His two friends.

7 On some day, in some particular mood, He would recite a verse and stay awake the whole night relishing it.

8 In joy the Lord said, “Listen, Svarūpa and Rāma Rāya! In the age of Kali the congregational chanting of the holy name is the supreme means.

9 In the age of Kali, Kṛṣṇa is worshiped by the sacrifice of *saṅkīrtana*. One who worships Him so is truly intelligent and attains Kṛṣṇa’s feet.”

10 “With sacrifices in which congregational chanting predominates, the wise worship the Lord who ever sings of Kṛṣṇa and whose lustre is not dark. He is always surrounded by His intimate companions (*aṅga*), His devotees (*upāṅga*), His weapons and His associates (*pārṣada*).” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 11.5.32)

11 “Through the congregational chanting of the holy name all unwanted things (*anartha*) are destroyed, every good fortune dawns, and the joy of love for Kṛṣṇa awakens.”

12 “The chanting of Śrī Kṛṣṇa’s name cleanses the mirror of the heart and puts out the great forest fire of material existence. It spreads the moonlight that opens the white lotus of the soul’s highest good; it is the very life of the bride of divine knowledge. It swells the ocean of bliss, gives at every step a taste of the full nectar, and bathes and cools the whole self. May the supreme chanting of Śrī Kṛṣṇa’s name be ever victorious!” (Śikṣāṣṭaka, 1)

13–14 “Through *saṅkīrtana* sin and material existence are destroyed, the heart is purified, and all the practices of devotion awaken. Love for Kṛṣṇa awakens, and one tastes the nectar of that love. One attains Kṛṣṇa and is immersed in the nectarean ocean of His service.”

15 Then dejection and humility arose in Him, and He recited another of His own verses; by hearing its meaning all sorrow and grief go away.

16 “O Lord, You have revealed many names, and in them You have invested all Your own potencies. You have fixed no time for remembering

them. Such is Your mercy, yet such is my misfortune that no attachment for them has arisen in me." (Śikṣāṣṭaka, 2)

17 "Different people have desires of many kinds, so out of mercy You have spread many names.

18 Whether eating or lying down, wherever one may be, one can chant the name. There are no rules of time or place, and through the name all perfection comes.

19 You divided all Your potency among the names and gave it to them. But such is my misfortune: I have no attachment for the name!"

20 "Svarūpa and Rāma Rāya, hear the verse that tells how one should chant the name so that love is born."

21 "Lower than a blade of grass, more tolerant than a tree, seeking no honour and offering honour to others, one should always sing the glories of Hari." (Śikṣāṣṭaka, 3)

22 "Though he is exalted, a Vaiṣṇava considers himself lower than grass, and like a tree he shows tolerance in two ways.

23 When a tree is cut down it says nothing, and even when it is drying up and dying it asks no one for water.

24 It gives its wealth to whoever asks anything of it; it endures heat and rain, yet shelters others.

25 Though exalted, a Vaiṣṇava should be free from pride. He should honor every living being, knowing it to be the dwelling of Kṛṣṇa.

26 Whoever chants Kṛṣṇa's name in this spirit awakens love for the feet of Śrī Kṛṣṇa."

27 As He spoke, the Lord's humility grew, and He began to beg Kṛṣṇa for pure devotion (*śuddha-bhakti*).

28 Such is the nature of love: one who is truly touched by love thinks, "I have not even a trace of devotion to Kṛṣṇa."

29 "O Lord of the universe, I desire neither wealth, nor followers, nor beautiful poetry. Birth after birth, may I have causeless devotion to You, my Lord." (Śikṣāṣṭaka, 4)[1]

30 "I do not beg for wealth, for followers or for beautiful poetry. O Kṛṣṇa, be merciful and give me pure devotion!"

31 In great humility He again begged for the gift of devotion in servitude, thinking of Himself as an ordinary soul caught in worldly existence.

32 "O son of Nanda, I am Your servant, yet I have fallen into the terrible ocean of material existence. Be merciful and consider me a speck of dust at Your lotus feet." (Śikṣāṣṭaka, 5)

33 "I am Your eternal servant, but I forgot You and fell into the ocean of material existence, bound by *māyā*.

34 Be merciful and make me like a speck of dust at Your feet, so that as Your servant I may serve You."

35 Again intense longing and humility arose in Him, and He begged Kṛṣṇa for the chanting of the holy name with love.

36 “When, as I chant Your name, will my eyes overflow with streaming tears, my voice falter and choke, and my body be covered with thrills of joy?” (Śikṣāṣṭaka, 6)

37 “Without the wealth of love, life is poor and futile! Make me Your servant and give me the wealth of love as my wages!”

38 Absorbed in another *rasa*, He felt the full force of separation, and in anxiety, dejection and humility He began to speak words of divine madness.

39 “In separation from Govinda, a moment seems to Me an age, My eyes pour tears like the rains, and the whole world seems empty.” (Śikṣāṣṭaka, 7)

40 “In My anxiety the day will not pass; a moment has become like an age! Like clouds in the rainy season, My eyes rain tears!

41 In separation from Govinda the three worlds have become empty! I burn as in a slow fire of husks, and yet life does not leave Me.

42 Kṛṣṇa has become indifferent to test Me, and all My friends say, ‘Ignore Kṛṣṇa.’”

43 As these thoughts arose, the very nature of spontaneous love dawned in Rādhā’s pure heart.

44 Jealousy, eagerness, humility, boldness and entreaty — all these emotions arose at once.

45 These emotions unsettled Rādhā’s mind, and before Her friends She spoke a bold verse.

46 In that same mood the Lord recited that verse, and as He recited it He Himself became like Her.

47 “Let Him embrace and crush in His arms this maidservant devoted to His feet, or break My heart by not appearing before Me. Let that unrestrained lover (*lampaṭa*) do with Me whatever He likes — He alone is the Lord of My life, and no one else.” (Śikṣāṣṭaka, 8)

48 “I am the maidservant of Kṛṣṇa’s feet, and He is the very abode of *rasa* and joy. He may embrace Me and make Me His own, or He may not let Me see Him and so wear away My body and mind — still He is the Lord of My life.

49 O friend, hear the resolve of My heart. Whether He shows Me love or kills Me with pain, Kṛṣṇa — and no one else — is the Lord of My life.

50 Sometimes He leaves the other women, and His body and mind are under My control. Making My good fortune plain, He pains them all by sporting with Me before their eyes.

51 Or else, libertine, cheat, brazen and deceitful as He is, He takes other women with Him and sports with them before My eyes just to pain My heart — still He is the Lord of My life.

52 I do not count My own pain; I desire only His happiness. His happiness is My whole aim. If by giving Me pain He finds great happiness, that pain is My greatest happiness.

53 If Kṛṣṇa desires some woman, longing for her beauty, and is unhappy because He cannot have her, I fall at her feet, take her by the hand and bring her to Him, and by arranging their pastimes I make Him happy.

54 When a beloved is angry with Kṛṣṇa, Kṛṣṇa is pleased; He delights in her scolding and rebukes. When she shows loving pique (*māna*) as is fitting, Kṛṣṇa delights in it, and she gives it up at a little coaxing.

55 Why does a woman live who does not know Kṛṣṇa's heart and yet is bitterly angry with Him? She counts her own happiness as gain — may a thunderbolt fall on her head! We desire only Kṛṣṇa's satisfaction.

56 If a *gopī* who is hostile to Me pleases Kṛṣṇa, and Kṛṣṇa desires her, I will go to her house and serve her as her maidservant. Then My happiness overflows.

57 The wife of a leprous *brāhmaṇa*, the crest jewel of chaste wives, served a prostitute for her husband's sake. She stopped the course of the sun, brought her dead husband back to life, and pleased the three principal deities.

58 Kṛṣṇa is My life; Kṛṣṇa is the treasure of My life; Kṛṣṇa is the very life of My life. I hold Him upon My heart and make Him happy by serving Him — this is My constant meditation.

59 My happiness lies in serving Him; Kṛṣṇa's happiness lies in union with Me. Therefore I offer Him My body. Kṛṣṇa treats Me as His beloved and calls Me the queen of His life, but I think of Myself as His maidservant.

60 The fullness of joy in serving the beloved is sweeter even than union. The goddess Lakṣmī is witness to this: though she dwells on Nārāyaṇa's heart, she longs to serve His feet, and she serves Him thinking of herself as His maidservant."

61 Śrī Gaura Rāya relished these words of Rādhā, which bear the marks of pure love. His mind grew unsteady with emotion, *sāttvika* symptoms pervaded His body, and He could no longer hold His mind and body still.

62 Pure love for the Lord of Vraja is like gold from the river Jāmbū: in it there is no trace of desire for one's own happiness. To make this love of His known to the world, the Lord composed this verse, and He composed songs that set out its meaning.[2]

63 Thus, absorbed in ecstatic emotion, Mahāprabhu recited some verses and spoke words of divine madness.

64 Earlier He had composed these eight verses to instruct the people; now He Himself relished them.

65 Whoever reads or hears the Lord's *Śikṣāṣṭaka* verses will find his loving devotion to Kṛṣṇa growing day by day.

66 Though the Lord is as deep as millions of oceans, He grows restless when the moon of His many emotions rises.

67–68 Whatever verses of Jayadeva, of the *Bhāgavata*, of Rāmānanda Rāya's drama and of the *Karṇāmṛta* suited each mood, He would recite in that mood and relish, absorbed in that emotion.

69 For twelve years He was in this state night and day, relishing the *rasa* of Kṛṣṇa with His two friends.

70 Even Ananta Himself, describing with His thousand mouths the *rasa* of all these pastimes, cannot reach their end.

71 How can a soul of small intelligence describe them? I touch one particle of them only to purify myself.

72 His actions and His words of divine madness have no limit; to describe them all would make the book enormous.

73 Of the pastimes that Vṛndāvana dāsa had described before me, I have given only a summary.

74 I have briefly told the “remainder” that he left untold, and even so the book has grown, because the pastimes are so many.

75 Therefore I cannot describe all those pastimes; offering my obeisances to them, I have brought my account to a close.

76 What little I have told is only an indication of the way; by following it one can relish those pastimes.

77 I cannot understand the Lord’s profound pastimes; my intellect cannot enter them, and so I cannot describe them.

78 Bowing at the feet of all the Vaiṣṇavas who hear this, I bring to a close my description of Śrī Caitanya’s deeds.

79 The sky is unlimited, yet each bird in it flies only as high as its strength allows.

80 So too Mahāprabhu’s pastimes have no shore on either side. Who, being only a *jīva*, can describe them fully?

81 I have described as much as my intelligence could reach — as if I had touched a single drop in the midst of the ocean.

82 Vṛndāvana dāsa, the vessel of Nityānanda’s mercy, is the original Vyāsa (*ādi-vyāsa*) of Caitanya’s pastimes.

83 Although the storehouse of all the pastimes lay before him, he described only a little and left the rest.

84 What little I have described, I too have told in brief: these are the things he could not write out in full, yet he left them recorded.

85 Here and there in the *Caitanya-maṅgala* he has written of them. Hear those words: they are the supreme evidence.

86 I have told it in brief, for it cannot be told in full. Vedavyāsa will describe it in detail.

87 He has written this here and there in the *Caitanya-maṅgala*, and he speaks the truth: afterwards Vyāsa described these pastimes.[3]

88 The ocean of the nectar of Caitanya's pastimes is like the ocean of milk. He filled his pitcher as his thirst required and drank.

89 He gave me a little of the nectar left in his pitcher; with that my stomach was filled and my thirst was gone.

90–91 I am a very tiny soul, like the little *rāṅgā-ṭuni* bird. As that bird, when thirsty, drinks the water of the ocean, so I have touched a single drop of the pastimes. By this example know how vast the Lord's pastimes are.

92 To think "I am writing" is a false notion: my body is like a wooden puppet.

93 I am old and infirm, blind and deaf; my hands shake, and my mind and intelligence are not steady.

94 Seized by many diseases, I can neither walk nor sit; tormented by the pain of five diseases, I am dying day and night.

95 I have already confessed this earlier in the book. Still I write — hear the reason for it.

96–98 Śrī Govinda, Śrī Caitanya, Śrī Nityānanda, Śrī Advaita, the devotees and the revered listeners; Śrī Svarūpa, Śrī Rūpa, Śrī Sanātana; Śrī Raghunātha dāsa, my *guru*, and the feet of Śrī Jīva — by the mercy of the feet of all these I am made to write. And there is One more: He shows me exceptional mercy.

99 Śrī Madana-Gopāla, by His order, makes me write. It is not fitting to say this, yet I cannot keep silent.

100 If I did not say it, I would be guilty of ingratitude. Though I speak as if out of pride, O listeners, do not be angry.

101 I have worshipped the dust of the feet of you all; by that has come about whatever little I have written of Caitanya's pastimes.

102 Now I shall recapitulate the pastimes of the Antya-līlā: by recapitulating (*anuvāda*) I relish the pastimes again.

103 In the first chapter: Rūpa's second meeting with the Lord, and in it the Lord's hearing of the plan of the two plays.

104 In it a dog came with Śivānanda, and the Lord, making it say "Kṛṣṇa", liberated it.

105 In the second: the lesson the Lord gave Choṭa Haridāsa, and in it Śivānanda's wonderful vision.

106 In the third: the mighty glory of Haridāsa, and Dāmodara Paṇḍita's rebuke to the Lord.

107 By giving the Holy Name, the Lord delivered the universe, and Haridāsa established the glory of the Name.

108 In the fourth: Śrī Sanātana's second meeting with the Lord, who saved him from giving up his body.

109 In the blazing sun of the month of Jyaiṣṭha the Lord tested him; then, investing him with power, He sent him back to Vṛndāvana.

110 In the fifth: the Lord's mercy to Pradyumna Miśra, whom He had hear talks of Kṛṣṇa from Rāmānanda Rāya.

111 In it: the rejection of the play of a "Bengali" poet, and Svarūpa Gosāñi's establishing the glory of the Deity (*vigraha*).

112 In the sixth: Raghunātha dāsa met the Lord, and by Nityānanda's order he held the festival of flat rice (*ciḍā*).

113 The Lord entrusted him to Svarūpa Dāmodara and gave him the stone from Govardhana and the *guñjā* garland.

114 In the seventh chapter: the meeting with Vallabha Bhaṭṭa, whose pride the Lord broke in various ways.

115 In the eighth: the arrival of Rāmacandra Purī, out of fear of whom the Lord reduced His meals.

116 In the ninth: the release of Gopīnātha Paṭṭanāyaka; and the people of the three worlds received the Lord's *darśana*.

117 In the tenth I told of the Lord's relishing what the devotees gave Him, and there of how Rāghava Paṇḍita packed his bags (*jhāli*).

118 In it the Lord tested Govinda, and in it is the description of the dance in a circle (*parimuṇḍā-nṛtya*).

119 In the eleventh: the departure of Haridāsa Ṭhākura, in which Gaura Bhagavān showed His affection for His devotees.

120 In the twelfth: Jagadānanda's breaking of the pot of oil, and Nityānanda's punishment of Śivānanda.

121 In the thirteenth: Jagadānanda went to Mathurā and came back, and Mahāprabhu heard the song of a *devadāsī*.

122 There too is the meeting with Raghunātha Bhaṭṭācārya, whom the Lord in His mercy sent to Vṛndāvana.

123 In the fourteenth: the description of the beginning of the divine madness — the Lord's "body" was here, His "mind" had gone to Vṛndāvana.

124 In it: the Lord's fall at the Siṁha-dvāra, the loosening of His joints, and the rise of ecstatic symptoms (*anubhāva*).

125 The Lord ran on seeing Caṭaka-parvata; and in it is a description of some of His ecstatic raving (*pralāpa*).

126 In the fifteenth chapter: the pastimes in the garden, which the Lord entered, taking it for Vṛndāvana.

127 In it: the attraction of the Lord's five senses, and in it His search for Kṛṣṇa in the *rāsa* dance.

128 In the sixteenth the Lord showed mercy to Kālidāsa and revealed the fruit of eating the remnants of Vaiṣṇavas.

129 The Lord had Śivānanda's boy compose a verse, and the doorkeeper of the Siṁha-dvāra showed Kṛṣṇa to the Lord.

130 There He described the glory of *mahā-prasāda* and relished the verse on the fruit of the nectar of Kṛṣṇa's lips.

131 In the seventeenth: the Lord's fall among the cows, and there the appearance of the ecstatic symptom of His tortoise-like form.

132 The qualities of Kṛṣṇa's sound drew the Lord's mind, and in ecstasy He explained the meaning of the verse *kā stry aṅga te*.

133 In a mingling of emotions (*bhāva-śābalya*) He again spoke in ecstatic raving, and He explained the meaning of a verse of the *Karṇāmṛta*.

134 In the eighteenth chapter: the Lord's fall into the ocean, and there His vision of the water-play of Kṛṣṇa and the *gopīs*.

135 There too He saw Kṛṣṇa's meal in the forest. A fisherman pulled Him out, and the Lord came back to His residence.

136 In the nineteenth: the Lord's rubbing His face against the wall, and the description of His raving as separation from Kṛṣṇa flashed within Him.

137 His wandering in a flower garden on a spring night, and His explanation of the verse on Kṛṣṇa's fragrance.

138 In the twentieth chapter: reciting His own *Śikṣāṣṭaka*, the Lord, absorbed in love, relished its meaning.

139 The *Śikṣāṣṭaka* He had spoken to teach the devotees — the meaning of those eight verses He relished once more.

140 I have told the substance of the principal pastimes; by recapitulation (*anuvāda*) the contents of the book are remembered.

141 Each chapter has topics of many kinds. I have told only the principal ones, for the story cannot be told at length.

142–143 Śrī Madana-mohana with Śrī Rādhā, the feet of Śrī Govinda with Śrī Rādhā, and beautiful Śrī Gopīnātha with Śrī Rādhā — these three Deities are the Lords of the Gauḍīyas.

144–146 Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, the glorious Nityānanda, Śrī Advaita Ācārya and the devotees of Śrī Gaura; Śrī Svarūpa, Śrī Rūpa, Śrī Sanātana; Śrī Raghunātha, my *guru*, and the feet of Śrī Jīva — I hold the feet of all these on my head, for from them comes the fulfilment of every desire.

147 The mercy of the feet of all of them is the teacher (*upādhyāyī*), and his speech is her pupil, whom she makes dance a great deal.[4]

148 Seeing the pupil's weariness, the teacher stopped the dance. When "mercy" does not make her dance, "speech" sits still.

149 Unskilled speech does not know how to dance by herself: she danced as much as she was made to dance, and then she rested.

150 I bow down at the feet of all my listeners, the mercy of whose feet is the cause of all good.

151 Whoever hears the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta* — I wash his feet and drink that water.

152 I make the dust of my listeners' feet the ornament of my head. You have drunk this nectar, and my labour has borne fruit.

153 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

154 Whoever with faith relishes this nectarean account of the life of Śrīla Caitanya, who is Viṣṇu Himself — an account that bestows all good and destroys all evil — becomes a bee at His spotless lotus feet and relishes to the full the *rasa* that overflows with the intoxicating honey of *prema*.[5]

155 For the satisfaction of Śrīman Madana-Gopāla and Govinda-deva, may this *Caitanya-caritāmṛta* be offered to Śrī Caitanya.

156 The lotus feet of Giridhara fill the world with their fragrance, and with their own *rasa* they intoxicate the bees who know *rasa*. What *rasika* would ever seek to abandon them?[6]

157 By the power of the dust of the lotus feet of my Mistress, Śrī Rādhikā — dust that is the whole wealth of my life — I surrender to Śrī Śrīla Govinda, the dust of whose lotus feet is dearer to Her than life and is Her all in all.[7]

158 In the Śaka year 1537, in the month of Jyaiṣṭha, in Vṛndāvana, on a Sunday, the fifth day of the dark fortnight, this book was completed.[8]

Notes

1. *Sundarīṁ kavitām*, “beautiful poetry”: so the *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* and the *Anubhāṣya* take the words (in the *Anubhāṣya*, eloquence and learning in the service of religiosity, wealth and pleasure); other translations take *sundarī* as “a beautiful woman.” ↩
2. The Gauḍīya Maṭha edition reads *vrajeśvara-śuddha-prema*, “pure love for the Lord of Vraja,” which is translated here; it notes the reading of another manuscript, *vrajera viśuddha prema*, “the pure love of Vraja.” ↩
3. So in the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition: *karilā varṇane*, “described”. Other manuscripts read *karibena varṇane*, “will describe” (cited in the *Anubhāṣya* as a variant). According to the *Anubhāṣya* (on verse 82), the

later pure *ācāryas* who wrote of Gaura's pastimes, following the "original Vyāsa" Vṛndāvana dāsa Ṭhākura, are also called "Vyāsa". ↩

4. So in the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition: *tāra vāṇī*, "his speech" — the author speaks of himself in the third person, as in the closing lines of the chapters. Other manuscripts read *mora vāṇī*, "my speech" (cited in the *Anubhāṣya* as a variant). *Upādhyāyī*, "teacher": according to the *Anubhāṣya*, here a teacher of the arts. ↩
5. The *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* takes *so 'yam* ("this one") as the author himself: at the spotless lotus feet of such a hearer the author becomes a bee and relishes this *rasa*. ↩
6. So in the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the *Anubhāṣya*: *rasajña-rolambam*, "bees who know *rasa*" — according to the *Anubhāṣya*, the *rasika* devotees intoxicated by the *rasa* of conjugal love (*śṛṅgāra*). Other manuscripts read *rasikālambam*, "the shelter of the *rasikas*". According to the *Anubhāṣya* (on verse 158), verses 156–158 are not found in many manuscripts. ↩
7. Translated according to the *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: "By the power of the dust of the lotus feet of her who is the all-in-all of my life, and meditating on the dust of the lotus feet that is dearer than life and the all-in-all to my Mistress Śrīmatī Rādhikā, I surrender to Śrī Śrī Govinda-deva." ↩
8. *Sindhu* (ocean) = 7, *agni* (fire) = 3, *bāṇa* (arrow) = 5, *indu* (moon) = 1; according to the *Anubhāṣya*, the digits are read from right to left: Śaka 1537 (A.D. 1615). ↩